> In taking any decision, the Government cannot ignore the overall interest of national unity, integrity, and the welfare of all sections of people.
>
> Government hopes and trusts that the representatives of the Akali Dal will look at their problems in the larger context. We repeat our invitation to them to come for further discussions and to create the right atmosphere for this by calling off or suspending their agitation. I hope that in the present circumstances nothing will be done which may escalate tension or will give rise to violence and suffering. I appeal to all parties to extend their cooperation.

The above statement, though also futuristic, deviated from the original statement shown to the Akalis in that it lacked the specificity that made it acceptable to them in the first place. There was no mention of a commission to look into Centre–state relations, no mention of river waters, no mention of Chandigarh. On top of that, instead of recognizing the contributions made by the Sikhs to the freedom struggle and nation building, oblique aspersions were being cast on their commitment to national unity and integrity.

Anxious to find the reason for this overnight change of statement, Swaran Singh left home soon after these calls. He went to Parliament House, where he met G.S Chawla, who asked him, 'Sardar Sahib, why this change in the government's stance?' Swaran Singh replied, 'This is neither the same statement nor the same spirit. Now I am going to withdraw from the negotiations,' and told Chawla that he could be quoted on this. [17] After that Swaran Singh decided not to get involved in future negotiations with the Akalis. Though he was repeatedly requested by Indira Gandhi to play some part in solving the Punjab problem, he kept away. [18]

There were various versions regarding the government's volte face. A few days after the statement was made in parliament, P.P. Nayyar told Chawla in strict confidence that it was changed by Indira Gandhi herself at 11 p.m., and a new statement was sent to the speaker and the home minister. [19] Chawla is of the view that